

SOUTHEAST

Pilot: "Syzygy"

by

David Quang Pham

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512 W 158th St #2 New York, New York 10032
david@flavorpictures.com
616 818 5413

Series

After their fathers vanish in a hurricane, the neighboring Senegalese American and Vietnamese American siblings must protect their Louisiana duplex from a magic-hungry French American landowner by using a captured will-o'-the-wisp to summon ancestors, who grow troubled by the kids' immature requests.

Episode

After capturing a supernatural spirit during a solar eclipse, two immigrant families in a Louisiana duplex must survive a hurricane and an ancient land-grabbing conspiracy when their fathers vanish, leaving the kids to defend their home alongside a foul-mouthed wrestling figure and a summoned 18th-century ancestor.

EXT. LOUISIANA WOODS - NIGHT (2017)

NOTHING... Then we hear the diverse sounds of the MARSH: croaks and chirps.

A FLOATING QUOTE APPEARS IN GLOWING, HANDWRITTEN SCRIPT:

"GÂN MUC THÌ DEN, GÂN DÈN THÌ SANG."

SUBTITLE: CLOSE TO INK THEN BLACK, NEAR BY LIGHT THEN BRIGHT.

An orb of yellow light known as a FIFOLLET zips past. It snuffs the words out like a candle wick.

In the distance, two teenagers are hardly visible in the brush. Dawn Chu (16), an emo-clad force of nature, watches. Beside her, Yoro Sakho (16) .

DAWN

Well, I'll be damned.

YORO

From research, that thing should double back...

DAWN'S POV: She STRIKES a match inches from Yoro's face.. The light illuminates a startled Senegalese Louisianan boy, YORO SAKHO (16). He flinches, squinting at the flame.

YORO (CONT'D)

(in French; subtitled)

Blind me before I see the damn thing.

DAWN

Lighten up cause ya won't catch up!

Dawn BOLTS. Her boots slap against the mud as she chases the glow. Yoro shakes off the spots in his eyes and charges after her, his sneakers skidding on exposed roots.

He runs past her and lunges and his fingers close around the glow.

CRACK. Yoro's foot sinks into a hole. He hits the mud face-first, his hands flying open.

The fifollet shoots out of his grip and dances mockingly over his head before zipping toward the horizon.

Yoro reaches out, his hand caked in mud, as the orb vanishes into the first blinding rays of the SUNRISE.

Dawn skids to a halt and pulls him up by his collar.

DAWN (CONT'D)
Classic Yoro. Ya finally felt the
sun and immediately tripped over
the Earth.

Dawn uses a thumb to smear mud off his forehead. Yoro ignores
the gesture, staring at the sky.

YORO
Today, we're not feeling the sun
cause it's...

DAWN & YORO
...the eclipse.

EXT. SAKHO-CHU DUPLEX - MORNING

The duplex is two shotgun houses, painted a sea-foam color.
On the Sakho north side, the porch is cluttered with futbols
and a broken lawnmower. The Chu south side has wind chimes.

Yoro, looking like he lost a wrestling match with a swamp,
creeps towards the Sakho porch.

INT. SAKHO HOME - CONTINUOUS

Yoro enters and quietly closes the door. He walks around the
home with his shoes on.

SAVANNA (V.O.)
(Disgruntled voice)
Walking in your shoes would make
the Chus' head go boom!

Yoro freezes.

SAVANNA SAKHO (12) sits at the dining table, holding BAKER G,
a hulking wrestling action figure with a championship belt.
She moves the figure's arm as if he's pointing at Yoro.

YORO
Savanna. It's six in the morning.

SAVANNA
(Normal voice)
Baker G had a nightmare about the
folding chair monster. Also, he
says you smell like failure... and
swamp rot?

YORO

I was out... calculating the
eclipse.

SAVANNA

I guess you can't calculate gravity
before you fell in mud, couillon?

Savanna circles Yoro like a shark.

SAVANNA (CONT'D)

Does Papa know you snuck out to
play with Dawn again?

YORO

No better time than sunrise.

SAVANNA

Not what I mean. You ain't chasing
sunrise...

(as Baker G)

Ya chasing fireflies!

YORO

Nonsense!

SAVANNA

I've seen your sketches.

YORO

Get outta my room!

Inside the kitchen, the THUD of a coffee pot hitting a
counter echoes. SALL SAKHO (37) is awake.

YORO (CONT'D)

(Hissing)

Savanna, don't. I'll give you my
PlayStation for a week.

SAVANNA

Two weeks. And you have to let
Baker G use your laptop to watch
Wrestle-Mania.

YORO

Fine!

Sall Sakho enters, with a sharp gaze. He's wearing an old
Geaux Tigers hoodie. He looks at Yoro's mud-caked clothes.

SALL

Yoro. Why are you wearing the marsh
on your face?

SAVANNA

He and Baker G were mudwrestling.
Of course, Baker G won.

She gives Yoro a "you owe me" look.

SALL

(Sighs)

Gee... Go wash. We leave for the
clearing in an hour. The Grenos are
already being... the Grenos. I
don't need you looking like a swamp
creature when we're trying to stay
on Fanny's good side.

Sall returns to his room. Yoro exhales, but Savanna lingers.
She holds Baker G up to Yoro's ear.

SAVANNA

(as Baker G)

The debt is recorded. Don't make me
come collect.

EXT. CHU PORCH - SAME TIME

Dawn sits, hunched over her notebook, scribbling dollar signs
and lyrics. The screen door CREAKS open.

EMMETT CHU (12) steps out. He wears a bathrobe and got on
some slippers, carrying a bowl of Marshmallow Matey.

DAWN

Ya look like you're waiting for a
spa treatment that's never coming.

EMMETT

I'm a monk, Dawn! I saw this guy on
YouTube who said if you don't speak
during a celestial event, your
brain, like, unlocks. I'm doing a
vow of silence.

DAWN

You're literally talking right now.

EMMETT

Wait, no- I mean, after I finish my
cereal! I'm in the pre-vow phase.
It's for my spiritual alignment.

DAWN

That robe? Bailey is gonna have a
field day.

Emmett shoves a spoonful of marshmallows.

EMMETT

Bailey's just a hater. Besides, if I don't talk, he can't make fun of what I say.

DAWN

(Closing her book)

Not making fun of what you're saying. Your sayings are just a load of garbage. You'll be a target. You're gonna be the only kid looking like a giant marshmallow.

EMMETT

It's comfortable! And it's got deep pockets for my eclipse glasses.

He tries to strike a zen pose but trips over the hem of the robe, nearly spilling his cereal.

DAWN

Nice. Very enlightened. The ground really felt your presence there.

EMMETT

Meant to do that. It was a... grounding exercise.

DAWN

Come on. Let's head to Uncle Minh before he grounds us.

Dawn helps Emmett up.

INT. YORO'S BEDROOM - LATER

The room is a cramped museum. Tacked to the walls are blurry polaroids of marshes and hand-drawn frantic red circles.

Yoro enters in a towel, coming in from a shower. He stares at a framed photograph on his desk: a smiling woman, holding a much younger Yoro. She's wearing a field jacket and holding a vintage compass.

YORO

Light is a constant. Truth is a constant. You didn't just walk into the trees and "dissolve," *Maman*. That ain't how matter works.

He pulls a worn, leather-bound journal from a hidden drawer. The first page is dated "The Night of the 2008 Surge." Underneath, a child's shaky handwriting describes a "yellow light that led the way."

He traces the sketch of a fifollet he drew when he was six. Every capture attempt since then—the jars, the light-meters, the math—isn't for a science fair. It's for a breadcrumb trail.

YORO (CONT'D)

Papa says you got lost in the rain.
Savanna says you're a star now. But
the fireflies... they're the only
ones who were there that night.

He grabs a fresh mason jar, his grip tightening.

YORO (CONT'D)

If I catch one, I can ask where the
"lost" go.

A thud against the wall—the shared duplex boundary—jolts him.

SAVANNA (O.S.)

Bruh! Baker G says we're gonna miss
the Extinction Event!

YORO

You put the stink in extinction!

SAVANNA

Dad! Yoro says I stink!

SALL (O.S.)

Yoro...

Yoro goes to exits, pauses at the door, glancing one last time at the compass in the photo.

YORO

I didn't say she stinks. I said she
should go—

Yoro leaves the room.

EXT. CLEARING - DAY

The clearing is a patch of grass surrounded by cypress trees.

A telescope sits on a tripod. Minh Chu (37) is adjusting the lens. He wears a space shirt.

Beside him, Emmett (12) wears a bathrobe and stares intensely at a blade of grass.

Dawn sits on the tailgate of a beat-up truck, sketching in a black notebook.

MINH

(to the telescope)

Don't be shy, baby. Show me the corona. I've waited since the '91 eclipse for this. I was eleven. I cried. I won't cry today.

DAWN

You're crying a little bit right now, Uncle Minh.

MINH

(Wiping a tear)

All allergies to mediocrity.

The Sakho's sedan rumbles into the clearing. Sall, Yoro, and Savanna, who is clutching Baker G, pile out.

SALL

I see you brought the big guns, Minh. Expecting to see God, or just my property line?

MINH

(Smirks)

Sall. I see you brought your children. Brave, considering Yoro looks like he was dragged behind a boat.

Sall looks at Yoro, then back to Minh. He holds up a cooler.

SALL

I brought Jollof. And some boudin from the shop.

MINH

(Softening)

I have spring rolls. And a very expensive solar filter. Sit. But don't touch the tripod or I will deport myself.

Yoro walks over to Dawn. He's wearing a clean shirt but still looks frazzled.

YORO

Found a spot for the camera?

DAWN

The universe is a void, Yoro. Why
record its blinking eye?

YORO

Because it only blinks once every
few decades?

DAWN

(Closing her book)

Terrible advice: You should have
stayed in the mud. The light is
going to be disappointing.

Suddenly, a LOUD CRUNCH of tires on gravel. A pristine white
SUV pulls up. BAILEY GRENOS (13) leans out the window,
wearing \$200 sunglasses.

BAILEY

Hey, look! It's the Duplex Circus!

FANNY GRENOS (66) climbs out of the driver's seat. She's
dressed in hunting camo but wears a string of real pearls.
She holds a walking stick like a scepter.

FANNY

Sall. Minh. I see you've made
yourselves comfortable on my
family's dirt.

SALL

Fanny. You said the clearing was
open for the neighborhood.

FANNY

It is. But the neighborhood usually
pays its rent on the first, Sall.
Not the fifth.

She scans the ground, her eyes lingering on the woods where
the fifollet vanished earlier.

FANNY (CONT'D)

Be careful where you kids play.
There's things in these woods that
don't belong to you.

Bailey jumps out and struts over to Emmett.

BAILEY

Hey, Monk-boy. Nice bathrobe. Did
your mom give it to you before she
left?

Emmett doesn't break character, but his lip quivers.

SAVANNA

Hey, Bailey. Baker G says your
breath smells like wet dog and
entitlement.

BAILEY

Shut up, squirt. Or what?

The sky DIMS. The birds stop chirping. A strange, silvery
twilight washes over the trees.

YORO

It's happening.

Yoro looks through his binoculars. In the reflection of the
glass, we see the moon's shadow taking a bite out of the sun.

Nearby, in the thick brush, a yellow glow pulses. It ain't no
nighttime fifolet. It's a DAYTIME FIFOLET. And she's watching
them.

The temperature drops. The wind dies. The silvery light turns
an eerie, bruised purple.

BAILEY

(to Emmett)

Check this out, loser. Special
eclipse trick.

Bailey pulls out a high-intensity laser pointer. He aims it
directly at Emmett's face.

YORO

Bailey, stop! You'll burn his
retinas!

MINH

(Lunging)

Hey! That's a three-thousand dollar
telescope—don't you dare!

Bailey laughs, swiping the beam across Emmett's eyes. Emmett
yelps, clutching his face and breaking his "monk" vow with a
high-pitched scream.

Before Sall or Minh can intervene, a blur of denim and braids
streaks across the grass.

SAVANNA

(as Baker G)

Extinction event!

Savanna tackles Bailey mid-laugh. They hit the dirt hard. She executes a headlock she clearly learned from late-night TV.

FANNY

Sall, get your wild animal off my
Bailey!

SALL

(Grabbing Savanna)
Savanna, lâche-le! Enough!

Sall pulls her back, but she manages to kick Bailey's expensive sunglasses into the weeds.

TOTALITY HITS.

The world goes black. A shimmering white ring—the Corona—burns in the sky. It is silent, terrifying, and beautiful.

DAWN

(Whispering)
It looks like the eye of a dead
god.

YORO

(Staring up)
It's perfect.

While the adults are shouting and Bailey is whimpering, a tiny spark of gold zips out of the brush. It isn't headed for the sun; it's headed for the chaos.

The fifollet—NAOMI—dives into the middle of the group. She zips around Savanna's head, then Dawn's.

DAWN

Yoro! The match!

Dawn doesn't wait. She lunges. She doesn't use a net; she uses her oversized emo beanie. With a violent SWISH, she traps the glow against her chest.

YORO

You got it? Dawn, did you get it?!

DAWN

My heart's beating...?

The sun begins to peek back out—the "Diamond Ring" effect. The light returns instantly, harsh and revealing.

Fanny is standing over them, her face contorted in rage.

FANNY

That's it. All of you. Off my land.
Sall, Minh—I want the back rent by
Monday or I'm calling the sheriff
to clear that duplex out.

MINH

Fanny, come on, the boy was
blinded—

FANNY

(Pointing to the exit)
OUT!

EXT. SAKHO-CHU DUPLEX - LATER

The mood is somber. Sall and Minh are on the porch, speaking
in hushed, stressed tones about money.

In the backyard, the four kids huddle around a glass pickle
jar.

Inside the jar, a single firefly pulses with an impossibly
bright, neon-gold light. Beside it, the BAKER G action figure
sits propped against the glass.

SAVANNA

She's beautiful. I'm naming her
Naomi. After the Glow Queen.

YORO

(Adjusting his glasses)
It's just a Photuris lucicrescens.
A firefly. The eclipse probably
messed with its bioluminescence.

DAWN

It's not a bug, Yoro. Look at how
she's looking at the doll.

Inside the jar, Naomi lands on Baker G's plastic shoulder.
The light from her tail begins to bleed into the plastic. The
action figure's tiny painted eyes seem to... flicker.

Suddenly, the wind picks up. Not a breeze—a HOWL. The palm
trees across the street bend nearly double.

SALL (O.S.)

Kids! Inside! The radio says the
cell just turned into a hurricane!

SAVANNA
(Grabbing the jar)
Come on, Naomi.

As they run for the door, the jar glows so bright it turns Savanna's hand transparent, revealing her bones like an X-ray.

INT. SAKHO LIVING ROOM - MOMENTS LATER

The house GROANS. Rain lashes against the siding like handfuls of gravel. Inside, the air is thick and smells of ozone and old chimney soot.

Sall paces, checking his phone. No bars.

SALL
The grid is down. Minh! You got the shutters on the south side?

MINH (O.S.)
(Through the wall)
The wind is pushing back, Sall!
It's like the house is fighting me!

The power suddenly goes out.

Savanna sits on the rug, the pickle jar between her knees.

SAVANNA
(as Baker G)
Baker G with an important announcement: bedtime!

Sall and Minh look at each other, amused.

INT. SAVANNA'S BEDROOM - NIGHT

Naomi brings Baker G to life.

Baker G wakes up Savanna. Baker G sounds like a woman.

SAVANNA
What did I eat?

BAKER G
You ate your vitamins.

SAVANNA
This has gotta be a dream...

BAKER G
Dreams are for sleepers!

SAVANNA
Sleepers?

BAKER G
Reality is for followers.

Baker G goes to the doorway. They open the outside screen door, revealing the pouring rain.

BAKER G (CONT'D)
We gotta match to catch!

SAVANNA
I ain't catching a cold...

Baker G grabs a match from a nearby matchbox. They light up the fireplace.

SAVANNA (CONT'D)
A match to catch... I see.

The fireplace turns into a doorway.

BAKER G
Come with me.

Savanna follows Baker G into the doorway.

A CRACK of lightning hits the backyard. The house shakes. The lights flicker and DIE.